Journal of Psychological Inquiry
2023, Vol. 27, No. 2, pp. 18-27
©Great Plains Behavioral Research Association

How informing and training students in self-compassion affects their academic attitudes following negative feedback

Georgette C. Early, Gabriella M. DeFelice,
Clare M. Kennedy, & Tammy L. Sonnentag
Xavier University

Abstract – Students can experience significant decrements in wellbeing—including increased mental health problems—during college, which can impact their academic performance (Kaya & Erdem, 2021). A contributor to students' wellbeing is self-compassion (Neff, 2003), so it is important to investigate the relationship between self-compassion and academic success. The current study examined if informing (providing *knowledge*) and training (providing *knowledge and practice*) or neither informing nor training (control) students in self-compassion impacts their academic attitudes (i.e., academic resilience) following the reception of false negative feedback. Participants (N = 90) were randomly assigned to one of three conditions: those in the knowledge condition watched a video on self-compassion, those in the knowledge and practice condition watched the video and completed a self-compassion worksheet, and those in the control condition did neither. Subsequently, students completed an academic assessment—via a reading comprehension test from an SAT practice test—and received either slightly or extremely negative feedback about their performance. Participants then completed measures assessing their self-compassion and academic resilience. Results revealed that participants who received extremely negative feedback, as compared to slightly negative feedback, reported significantly higher levels of self-compassion. Additionally, among participants who provided *slightly negative* feedback, those who were trained (provided *knowledge and practice*) in self-compassion reported more self-compassion than participants in the control condition (who were not informed of nor trained in self-compassion). No effect emerged on students' academic resilience.

Keywords: self-compassion, academic resilience, false negative feedback

According to the American Council on Education, about 33% of college students meet the criteria for a clinically significant mental health problem (e.g., depression, anxiety, eating disorder, self-injury), which translates to nearly seven million students nationwide (Lipson et al., 2019). In addition, the Clay Center for Young Healthy Minds reports that 80% of college students describe feeling overwhelmed with academic life, and 45% report feelings of hopelessness (Glass et al., 2022). Clearly, students experience significant wellbeing-related problems during college, with wellbeing impacting their academic performance (Kaya & Erdem, 2021). One valuable contributor to students' wellbeing and academic performance is self-compassion. Self-compassion involves viewing pain and shortcomings as part of the shared human experience as well as the capacity to speak and think kindly of oneself (Neff, 2003). Because research reveals that self-compassion is associated with adaptive academic motivational patterns, such as viewing academic failures as learning opportunities (Neff et al., 2005), finding ways to promote students' self-compassion should be a focus of ongoing research. Consequently, the current study examines how informing (i.e., providing *knowledge*) and training (i.e., providing *knowledge and practice*) or neither informing nor training (control) students in self-compassion may promote their academic wellbeing. Specifically, the current study examines if informing and training students on self-compassion can promote their academic wellbeing following the delivery of slightly or extremely false negative feedback about their academic performance.

Self-Compassion and Academic Success

Heightened self-compassion has been repeatedly linked with academic success including, but not limited to, the formation and pursuit of more positive achievement-related goals (Arslan, 2016; Breines & Chen, 2012; Martin et al., 2019; Neff et al., 2005) and greater adaptive coping strategies in response to academic failures (Breines & Chen, 2012; Fong and Loi, 2016; Neff et al., 2005). As an example of the connection between self-compassion and academic success, Neff et al. (2005) examined the association between students' self-compassion and their achievement-based academic goals. Using a correlational design, Neff et al. (2005) measured students' self-compassion, mastery goals (i.e., performance approach tendencies that are reflective of their curiosity and the desire to develop new knowledge and skills), and performance-avoidance tendencies (i.e., reflecting individuals' concerns with not looking incompetent or inferior to others). Results revealed that greater levels of self-compassion predicted more performance approach tendencies and less performance avoidance tendencies. These results suggest that self-compassion is meaningfully associated with students' academic motivational patterns, with greater self-compassion being associated with better motivation. In a follow-up study, Neff et al. (2005) examined if students' self-compassion remains a strong predictor of their achievement-based academic goals even when they experience an academic failure (i.e., dissatisfactory midterm grade). Again, using a correlational design, students were asked to complete measures assessing their self-compassion, mastery goals, and performance-avoidance tendencies. Students completed these measures on a class day immediately following the receipt of a dissatisfactory course grade (i.e., failure) on a midterm exam. Results revealed that, even in the context of academic failure, students who reported greater levels of self-compassion also reported more mastery goals and less performance avoidance tendencies. The findings nicely demonstrate how self-compassion affects students' academic achievement goals, even after academic failure.

Although self-compassion has been linked with positive academic goals (Martin et al., 2019; Neff et al., 2005), such work provides little knowledge about if self-compassion can help reduce students' (academically related) distress. Such work was the focus of research by Fong and Loi (2016) who examined the association between self-compassion and students' distress. In the study, distress was operationalized with various measures, including stress, burnout, and depression. Results revealed that higher levels of self-compassion were significantly negatively correlated with all measures of distress. Additionally, self-compassion was shown to mediate the relationship between measures of distress such that, for example, the positive relationship between stress and depression was reduced or eliminated after controlling for the effects of self-compassion. Such results demonstrate that self-compassion may be an important variable in helping students attenuate distress and suggest that efforts to promote self-compassion among students may be a fruitful means to promote their wellbeing.

Knowledge of and Exposure to Self-Compassion

Despite the literature demonstrating the (academic) benefits of self-compassion, many people are not self-compassionate (Chwyl et al., 2021; Neff, 2003). Consequently, researchers have examined various ways to promote individuals' self-compassion. For example, in an experimental study by Chwyl et al. (2021), inducing positive (pleasant)—compared to negative (unpleasant)—beliefs about self-compassion predicted individuals' self-reported levels of self-compassion five to seven days later. Specifically, in the study, Chwyl et al. randomly assigned individuals to read one of two fictitious articles describing how self-compassion either facilitates or hinders personal growth and goal achievement. After at least five days, participants reported their intentions to practice self-compassion. Results revealed that individuals who read about how self-compassion facilitates personal growth and goal achievement reported a greater willingness to engage in self-compassion compared to those who read about how self-compassion hinders personal growth and goal achievement. Such work is consistent with literature (see, for example, Miller & Kelly, 2020) demonstrating that describing the value of self-compassion to individuals and therefore providing them accurate knowledge about self-compassion, may be a valuable strategy for promoting its practice.

Although knowledge of and exposure to self-compassion appear to be important factors promoting individuals' willingness to engage in self-compassion, the strongest method for promoting individuals' use of self-compassion may (arguably) be giving them actual opportunities to engage in—and directly practice—self-compassion. In an effort to do just that, Neff and Germer (2012) conducted a randomized control trial to examine if a self-compassion program could effectively make people more self-compassionate. In the study, participants were randomly assigned to participate (or not) in eight weekly, two-hour, meetings focused on providing individuals knowledge of and practice with self-compassion. The eight meetings provided participants with different information (i.e., knowledge) about self-compassion as

well as opportunities to practice self-compassion (e.g., writing a letter to oneself from the perspective of an ideally compassionate friend). Results revealed that participants in the eight-week program reported significantly higher levels of self-compassion than participants in the control group, with differences maintained at six-month and one-year follow-ups. Such work demonstrates the benefits of providing individuals with both knowledge of and self-compassion practice.

Current Study

It is relatively clear from previous research that self-compassion is linked with many benefits (Neff et al., 2005). Although prior research has demonstrated that individuals who learn about (Chwyl et al., 2021; Neff & Germer, 2012) and practice self-compassion (Neff & Germer, 2012) experience these benefits, we are unaware of a single study that has experimentally examined the relative impact of acquiring knowledge—compared to acquiring knowledge *and* engaging in practice—on individuals' self-compassion tendencies. Consequently, we pursued this question and did so in a sample potentially in need of greater self-compassion: college students. Specifically, the current study examines how informing (i.e., providing *knowledge*) and training (i.e., providing *knowledge and practice*) or neither informing nor training (control) college students on self-compassion affects their self-compassion and academic resilience following the delivery of false negative feedback about their academic performance. It was hypothesized that students who learn (i.e., obtain knowledge) about *and* practice self-compassion will report higher degrees of self-compassion and greater academic resilience compared to students who only learn about self-compassion (or those who do neither learn nor practice; control). We expected this pattern of results to emerge particularly when feedback on academic performance was slight, compared to extremely, negative.

Method

Participants

A total of 90 undergraduate students at a mid-sized private university in the Midwest (17 men, 67 women, 4 non-binary, and 2 chose not to identify) participated in the study. Participants were recruited through the School of Psychology's participant pool in exchange for 0.5 hours of research credit to fulfill a course requirement. Participants ranged in age from 18 to 26 (M = 20.12, SD = 1.15) years, with the majority identifying as White/Caucasian (n = 72; 80%) and fewer identifying as Hispanic or Latino/a (n = 6; 6.7%), biracial or multiracial (n = 4; 4.4%), Asian (n = 2; 2.2%), Black or African American (n = 2; 2.2%), or prefer not to respond (n = 4; 4.4%). All participants provided informed consent before taking part in the study, which was conducted online using Qualtrics survey software and, therefore, completed at a time and location convenient to them.

Design

The study was conducted as a 3 (Self-Compassion Skills: Knowledge, Knowledge and Practice, and Control) x 2 (SAT False Negative Feedback: Slightly Negative, Extremely Negative) between-subjects experimental design. The dependent variables were the students' self-compassion and academic resilience.

Materials and Measures

Self-Compassion Intervention

An educational video (My Best Self 101, 2019; https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iIa-A9mZHAE) was used to inform (i.e., provide *knowledge* to) participants on the construct of self-compassion, which involves the practice of extending kindness towards oneself in times of suffering or failure. The video describes how individuals are inherently deserving of self-kindness, and how those who practice self-kindness are better able to overcome barriers and thrive. In addition to the video, some participants were also trained (i.e., provided *practice*) in self-compassion by completing a 10-question worksheet, developed for the current study by translating an audio guide ("General Self-Compassion Break"; https://self-compassion.org/category/exercises/#guided-meditations; Neff, n.d;) into a worksheet. Specifically, the audio guide contains reflective prompts—which encourage the practice of self-compassion—that were translated into the worksheet (see Appendix A). For example, in the audio guide, listeners are asked to recall a situation when they suffered or struggled. For the current study, this prompt was adapted to ask participants to recall a situation when they suffered or struggled academically.

SAT Assessment and False Feedback

To presumably measure participants' academic performance, they completed a reading comprehension test from an SAT practice test (College Board SAT Practice Test 1, 2016). Specifically, the reading comprehension test required participants to read a short passage and answer 11 multiple-choice questions related to their understanding of the content. Participants' actual performance was neither evaluated nor described to them, rather they were provided false feedback describing their performance as either "slightly below average" or "extremely below average" relative to peers at the university (see Appendix B). The false feedback was consistent with information provided to participants in

prior research utilizing false feedback on academic work (Saeed & Sonnentag, 2018).

Self-Compassion

Raes et al.'s (2011) 12-item Self-Compassion Short Form (SCS-SF) was used to measure participants' ability to view suffering as a part of the shared human experience as well as their capacity to speak and think kindly about themselves. Participants responded to the items using a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*almost never*) to 5 (*almost always*). Example items include "When I fail at something important to me I become consumed by feelings of inadequacy" (reverse-scored) and "I try to see my failings as part of the human condition." After reverse scoring six negatively keyed items, scores across all items were averaged, with higher scores reflecting greater self-compassion.

Academic Resilience

An adapted version of Ricketts et al.'s (2017) measure of Academic Resilience in Mathematics was used to assess students' perceptions of their academic resilience in college. The measure was adapted to reflect *general* academic resilience as opposed to resilience *in* mathematics. For example, the item "I'm good at dealing with setbacks (e.g., bad mark, negative feedback on my worth) in math" was revised to read "I'm good at dealing with setbacks (e.g., bad marks, negative feedback on my worth) in school." The measure includes nine items rated on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 6 (*strongly agree*). Scores were averaged, with higher scores reflecting higher levels of academic resilience.

Procedure

Before data collection, IRB approval was obtained. The study was conducted online using Qualtrics survey software. After volunteering to participate via the School of Psychology's electronic participant pool system, Sona Systems, participants clicked a URL directing them to complete an informed consent form in Qualtrics. After providing informed consent, participants were randomly assigned—using settings available in Qualtrics—to one of six conditions where they were informed (i.e., provided *knowledge*), trained (provided *knowledge* and *practice*), or neither informed nor trained (control) in self-compassion followed by receiving false feedback that was either slightly or extremely negative feedback about their performance on a reading comprehension test from an SAT practice test. Specifically, participants either viewed a video promoting their knowledge of self-compassion, viewed the video *and* completed a 10-question self-compassion worksheet, or neither viewed the video nor completed the worksheet (control condition). Next, participants completed the reading comprehension section on the College Board's SAT Practice Test 1, which included 11 questions serving to assess their academic performance. Upon completion of the reading comprehension assessment, participants received negative feedback describing their performance as slightly below or extremely below average relative to peers at the university. Participants then completed measures assessing their Self-Compassion and Academic Resilience. Finally, participants reported demographic information, were thanked, and debriefed, including informing participants of the false feedback.

Results

To test the hypotheses that training (providing *knowledge* and *practice*) of self-compassion would be especially helpful in promoting students' use of self-compassion—as well as their resiliency in response to adverse academic feedback (i.e., academic resilience)—after receiving extremely negative feedback about academic performance, separate 3 (Self-Compassion: Knowledge, Knowledge and Practice, Control) x 2 (False Feedback: Slightly Below Average, Extremely Below Average) between-subjects analysis of variance (ANOVA) were conducted.

Self-Compassion

The main effect of the Self-Compassion condition was not significant, revealing no differences in students' self-reported self-compassion after being informed (provided knowledge; $M = 2.52$, $SD = .53$), trained (provided knowledge and practice; $M = 2.75$, $SD = .59$), or neither informed nor trained (control; $M = 2.59$, $SD = .74$), $F(2, 90) = 1.20$, $p = .31$. However, the main effect of the False Feedback was significant, revealing that students who received extremely below average feedback ($M = 2.75$, $SD = .67$) reported higher levels of self-compassion than students who received slightly below average feedback ($M = 2.51$, $SD = .56$), $F(1, 90) = 4.12$, $p = .05$. Finally, the interaction between the Self-Compassion condition and False Feedback was significant, $F(2, 90) = 3.62$, $p = .03$ (see Table 1). Post hoc simple effects tests revealed that when participants were provided *slightly negative* feedback, those who were trained (provided *knowledge and practice*) reported more self-compassion than participants in the control condition (who were neither informed of nor trained in self-compassion). In contrast, when participants were provided *extremely negative* feedback, participants' self-reported levels of self-compassion did not differ whether they were or were not informed of or trained in self-compassion (i.e., no differences between *knowledge, knowledge and practice,* or control).

Table 1
Means (and Standard Deviations) Associated with the Significant Interaction Between Self-Compassion Condition and False Feedback on Self-Reported Levels of Self-Compassion

Measure	Knowledge & Practice of Self-Compassion	Knowledge of Self-Compassion	No Knowledge of Self-Compassion
Slightly Negative Feedback	2.69 (.59)	2.57 (.53)	2.22 (.44)
Extremely Negative Feedback	2.81 (.61)	2.48 (.54)	2.96 (.81)

Table 2
Means (and Standard Deviations) Associated with the Non-Significant Interaction Between Self-Compassion Condition and False Feedback on Academic Resilience

Measure	Knowledge & Practice of Self-Compassion	Knowledge of Self-Compassion	No Knowledge of Self-Compassion
Slightly Negative Feedback	3.91 (0.66)	4.07 (0.60)	3.79 (0.54)
Extremely Negative Feedback	4.29 (0.80)	3.93 (0.82)	4.03 (0.54)

Academic Resilience

The main effect of Self-Compassion condition was not significant, revealing no differences in students' self-reported academic resilience whether they were informed (provided *knowledge;* $M = 3.99$, $SD = 0.72$), trained (provided knowledge and practice; $M = 4.10$, $SD = 0.75$) or neither informed nor trained (control; $M = 3.91$, $SD = 0.55$), $F(2, 84) = 0.60$, $p = .55$. The main effect of the False Feedback was also not significant, revealing that students who received feedback describing their performance as extremely negative ($M = 4.09$, $SD = 0.74$) did not report greater academic resilience than students who received feedback describing their performance as slightly below average ($M = 3.92$, $SD = 0.61$), $F(1, 84) = 1.21$, $p = .27$. Finally, the interaction between the Self-Compassion condition and False Feedback was not significant, $F(2, 84) = 1.21$, $p = .30$ (see Table 2).

Discussion

Extending previous research on the role of self-compassion on academic wellbeing, the current study examined if informing (providing *knowledge*) and training (providing *knowledge and practice*) or neither informing nor training (control) students in self-compassion impacts their self-compassion and academic resilience following the reception of false negative feedback. Results revealed that participants who received extremely negative feedback on their academic performance, as compared to those receiving slightly negative feedback, reported significantly higher levels of self-compassion. Additionally, among participants who received slightly negative feedback, those who were trained (provided *knowledge and practice*) in self-compassion reported more self-compassion than those who were neither informed nor trained on self-compassion (control). These findings provide important directions for future research on the topic.

One of the primary purposes of the current study was to examine if students who received slightly negative feedback about their academic performance would report higher levels of self-compassion and academic resilience than those who received extremely negative feedback. Contrary to prediction, students who received *extremely negative* feedback reported higher levels of self-compassion—but this effect did not extend to higher levels of academic resilience—compared to students who received *slightly negative* feedback. Although students' greater self-compassion in response to extremely negative feedback was surprising, it may be that self-compassion is less necessary in situations where performance is relatively adequate (i.e., slightly below

average performance in the current study). Rather, heightened self-compassion was reported when it was likely needed (i.e., when learning performance was extremely below average). Such findings suggest that students may know *when* to have self-compassion, which aligns with prior research (see Fong & Loi, 2016) revealing that students who report high degrees of academic distress also report high degrees of self-compassion. Future research could provide students with a broader range of academic feedback (e.g., extremely above average, slightly above average, average, slightly below average, and extremely below average) to understand if they truly delineate when to practice self-compassion.

If students do delineate when to practice self-compassion, it is curious why those who received *extremely negative* feedback did not report higher levels of self-compassion after being informed about (i.e., provided knowledge) or informed and trained (i.e., provided knowledge and practice) compared to control. One possible explanation is that when students receive *extremely* negative feedback, a single prior opportunity to learn about (i.e., be provided knowledge) or practice self-compassion is not enough to affect their wellbeing. This idea has merit because prior research (see Kaya & Erdem, 2021) suggests that when students experience a significant academic failure, their ability to think positively about themselves may be compromised. Future research might examine the boundaries of this idea, such that repeated training in self-compassion—rather than the single instance of training that was offered in the current study—may be more likely to impact students' wellbeing following severe negative feedback. Such a suggestion is consistent with research demonstrating the success of longer training—eight weekly meetings—on individuals' self-compassion (Neff & Germer, 2012).

One of the major findings in the current study revealed that among students who were provided *slightly negative* feedback, those who were trained (provided *knowledge and practice*) reported more self-compassion than students in the control condition (who were neither informed of nor trained in self-compassion). This finding is consistent with previous literature describing that exposure to self-compassion, through information and training, can increase individuals' self-compassion levels (Miller & Kelly 2020). Interestingly, however, the current study revealed that *only* informing students about self-compassion (i.e., providing only knowledge and no practice) was not enough to increase their self-compassion levels compared to neither informing nor training (control) them on self-compassion. Consequently, it appears that the combination of knowledge *and* practice—rather than knowledge alone—may most readily encourage students to use self-compassion in response to difficult situations. Such a conclusion is consistent with Neff and Germer's (2012) research, where a mindfulness program including both knowledge and practice increased individuals' self-compassion compared to control. Although the finding is consistent with prior work, it is possible that participants "took the hint" from the experimental materials (i.e., practice being self-compassionate) that they were expected to evince self-compassionate attitudes. Future studies may want to rule out such a possibility.

Although the current study revealed that students who received slightly negative feedback about their academic performance reported higher levels of self-compassion than those who received extremely negative feedback, the false feedback did not affect the students' self-reported academic resilience. One explanation may be that students' performance on the SAT assessment—as delivered through a research opportunity in the current study—lacked mundane realism and did not truly have implications for their future academic success (as a "real" SAT might). Because academic resilience is a quality that helps students overcome challenges that thwart their academic goals, the lack of real implications for poor performance on the SAT may have made it unlikely that they needed academic resilience.

Limitations and Future Directions

Although there are many strengths of the current study, particularly the experimental nature of the work, the limitations provide meaningful directions for future research. One of the primary limitations of the current study may be the believability of the false negative feedback provided to participants. Despite using procedures from prior research (see Sonnentag & Saeed, 2018), it is possible that students simply did not believe the feedback, particularly when their performance was described as extremely below average (i.e., severe negative feedback). Future research should assess the believability of false academic feedback or consider the contexts—such as actual classroom assessments—that make such feedback more believable (and, arguably, valuable to students).

A second limitation worthy of noting reflects the current study's sample, which involved a cross-sectional group of students recruited via convenience sampling procedures from a single mid-sized private university. Although it is important to study self-compassion on a college campus, the results may not be generalizable beyond college students. Future research should use a representative sampling strategy to understand the extent

to which providing students' knowledge or knowledge and practice in self-compassion can impact their academic attitudes. Such research may be particularly valuable if performed longitudinally, to examine the role of knowledge and practice in self-compassion on students' academic performance and persistence across time.

Conclusion

Overall, the current study examined if informing (providing *knowledge*) and training (providing *knowledge and practice*) or neither informing nor training (control) students in self-compassion impacts their academic attitudes following the reception of false negative feedback. Results revealed that participants who received extremely negative feedback on their academic performance, as compared to those receiving slightly negative feedback, reported significantly higher levels of self-compassion. Additionally, among participants who received slightly negative feedback, those who were trained (provided *knowledge and practice*) in self-compassion reported more self-compassion than those who were neither informed nor trained on self-compassion (control). Although the results were not as hypothesized, they have implications for research on self-compassion and may help inform directions for future research. What is clear is that research on self-compassion among college students should continue as the four-year college experience tends to be a time when individuals experience significant decrements in wellbeing, including increased mental health problems (Kaya & Erdem, 2021).

References

Arslan, C. (2016). Interpersonal Problem Solving, Self-Compassion and Personality Traits in University Students. *Educational Research and Reviews*, *11*(7), 474-481. http://dx.doi.org/10.5897/ERR2015.2605

Breines, J. G., & Chen, S. (2012). Self-compassion increases self-improvement motivation. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, *38*(9), 1133-1143. https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167212445 5

Chwyl, C., Chen, P., & Zaki, J. (2021). Beliefs about self-compassion: Implications for coping and self-improvement. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, *47*(9), 1327-1342. https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167220965303

College Board. (2016). SAT practice test #1. *SAT Suite of Assessments – College Board*, 5-7. https://satsuite.collegeboard.org/media/pdf/sat-practice-test-1.pdf

Fong, M., & Loi, N. (2016). The mediating role of self-compassion in student psychological health. *Australian Psychologist*. https://doi.org/10.1111/ap.12185

Glass, E., Schlozman, S., & Beresin, G. (2022). The college mental health crisis: A call for cultural change – Part 2. *The Clay Center for Young Healthy Minds,* https://www.mghclaycenter.org/parenting-concerns/college-mental-health-crisis-call-cultural-change-part-2/

Kaya, M., & Erdem, C. (2021). Students' well-being and academic achievement: A meta-analysis study. *Child Indicators Research*, 14, 1743–1767. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12187-021-09821-4

Lipson, S. K., Abelson, S., Ceglarek, P., Phillips, M., & Eisenberg, D. (2019). Investing in student mental health. *American Council on Education*. https://www.acenet.edu/Documents/Investing-in-Student-Mental-Health.pdf

Martin, R. D., Kennett D. J., & Hopewell, N. M. (2019). Examining the importance of academic-specific self-compassion in the academic self-control model. *The Journal of Social Psychology*, *159*(6), 676-691. https://doi.org/10.1080/00224545.2018.1555128

Miller, K., & Kelly, A. (2020). Is self-compassion contagious? An examination of whether hearing a display of self-compassion impacts self-compassion in the listener. *Canadian Journal of Behavioural Science / Revue canadienne des sciences du comportement*, *52*(2), 159-170. https://doi.org/10.1037/cbs0000150

My Best Self 101. (2019, August 27). *What is self-compassion?* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iIa-A9mZHAE

Neff, K. D. (n.d.). General self-compassion break [Audio recording]. *Self-Compassion Guided Practices and Exercises*. https://self-compassion.org/category/exercises/#guided-meditations

Neff, K. D. (2003). Self-Compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself. *Self and Identity, 2*(2), 85–101. https://doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

Neff, K. D., Hsieh, Y., & Dejitterat, K. (2005). Self-compassion, achievement goals, and coping with academic failure. *Self and Identity*, 4, 263-287. https://doi.org/10.1080/13576500444000317

Neff, K. D., & Germer, C. K. (2012). A pilot study and randomized controlled trial of the mindful self-compassion program. *Journal of Clinical Psychology, 69*(1), 28-44. https://doi.org/10.1002/jclp.21923

Raes, F., Pommier, E., Neff, K. D., & Van Gucht, D. (2011). *Self-Compassion Scale – Short Form*

(SCS-SF) [Database record]. PsycTESTS. https://dx.doi.org/10.1037/t10179-000

Ricketts, S. N., Engelhard, G., Jr., & Chang, M.-L. (2017). *Academic Resilience in Mathematics Scale* [Database record]. PsycTESTS. https://dx.doi.org/10.1037/t61033-000

Saeed, Z., & Sonnentag, T. L. (2018). Role of self-compassion on college students' social self-evaluations and affect across two domains. *Psi Chi Journal of Psychological Research, 23*(2), 132–141. https://doi.org/10.24839/2325-7342.JN23.2.94

Author Note

We would like to thank Dr. Christian End for his feedback on the initial ideas for this study.

Appendix A

Self-Compassion Worksheet

Recall and think about a time when you have suffered or struggled academically. Try your best to bring this situation to life.

1. Please write about this academic situation in detail.
2. How does this academic situation make you feel about yourself?
3. Please type the following phrase. “This is a moment of struggle. This is really hard right now.”
4. What does this phrase mean to you in the context of the academic situation?
5. Please type the following phrase. “Struggling is a part of life. It's okay to feel this way.”
6. What does this phrase mean to you in the context of the academic situation?
7. Please type the following phrase. “May I be kind to myself at this moment.”
8. How can you be kind to yourself in the context of the academic situation?
9. What would you say to a friend who was going through the same situation as you? Please do not use the friend’s real name in this response.
10. Please write down how you feel at this exact moment.

Appendix B

False Feedback

Below is information about your performance on the academic assessment. Please, very carefully, review the feedback on your performance.

Note: Participants were randomly assigned to see *one* of the following feedback conditions. Underlined text (see below) was used to draw participants' attention to the information.

Slightly Below Average Academic Ability

Academic Competence Test Score: students at Xavier University completed the SAT Test Questions.

Your performance ranked: **SLIGHTLY BELOW AVERAGE.**

Your performance on the academic competence test indicates that your <u>academic proficiency is slightly below average at Xavier University.</u>

Extremely Below Average Academic Ability

Academic Competence Test Score: students at Xavier University completed the SAT Test Questions.

Your performance ranked: **EXTREMELY BELOW AVERAGE.**

Your performance on the academic competence test indicates that your <u>academic proficiency is extremely below average at Xavier University.</u>